identity remains protected for security reasons, claims to have recorded the alleged conversations on a mobile phone without Singh's knowledge. The tapes, which run for over 48 minutes, allegedly capture Biren Singh discussing plans for "protecting" those involved in the violence and even boasting of defying Union home minister Amit Shah's orders to avoid excessive force. "Let them use bombs covertly, not openly," the voice in the tape suggests, dismissing Shah's directive as naïve. The recordings go on to detail how Singh allegedly shielded those who had looted thousands of weapons from state arsenals, even refusing to arrest them as he felt their actions aligned with his broader political strategy. INDIA TODAY, which has access to these tapes, was unable to independently confirm their authenticity.

In July, the Kuki body handed over the sensational audio files to the Justice Ajai Lamba Commission, established by the Union ministry of home affairs (MHA) last June to examine the factors behind the violence. Despite the gravity of the recordings, the KOHRT alleges, the commission took no action to verify or investigate their contents for months. This delay has led the petitioners to question the impartiality of the government's investigation, ultimately prompting them to approach the Supreme Court for a court-monitored probe by a Special Investigation Team (SIT).

Represented by human rights advocate Prashant Bhushan, the petitioners argued that the audio tapes, if authenticated, show not just the chief minister's negligence but also his active complicity. "He admitted to fuelling the insurgency, to allowing arms to be looted and to protecting those involved," Bhushan argued before the court. But Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, pushing for the petition to be dismissed or at least transferred to the Manipur High Court, suggested that the Supreme Court was intervening from an "ivory tower" without a clear understanding of conditions on the ground. Former CJI D.Y. Chandrachud, presiding over a three-judge bench just two days before his retirement, responded sharply, stating, "It is because we are not in an ivory tower that we are hearing this case. We are very much aware of our duty as a constitutional court and we cannot brush things under the carpet." The court then ordered the petitioners to provide additional materials verifying the tapes' authenticity before the bench decides on the next steps.

EVER SINCE THEY SURFACED, THE AUDIO RECORDINGS HAVE SPARKED FIERCE DEBATE AND INCITED FURTHER DISTRUST AMONG COMMUNITIES

Ever since they surfaced, the recordings have sparked fierce debate and incited further distrust among communities in Manipur. On its part, the Manipur government has categorically denied the authenticity of these recordings, describing them as part of a "malicious campaign" to destabilise the state and undermine the peace process. The state directorate of information and public relations issued a statement labelling the tapes as "doctored" and noting that social media analysis revealed a coordinated effort to disseminate the recordings,

FAR-REACHING IMPLICATIONS



A HISTORY OF VIOLENCE Houses set ablaze after a clash between Meiteis and Kukis in Manipur, May 2023

ANI

- **Supreme Court to examine audio recordings allegedly showing Manipur CM Biren Singh's complicity in ethnic violence that has left over 230 dead and 60,000 displaced**
- **Kuki rights group has petitioned for a court-monitored probe by an SIT; government claims tapes are doctored, has filed cybercrime FIR**
- **High-stakes probe could impact Biren Singh's political survival and the BJP's standing in Northeast. If found doctored, would vindicate both**
- **It could also set precedent in matters of alleged state complicity in communal violence and Indian judiciary's role in holding powerful officials accountable**